

spread in brick troughs throughout the room. Unidentified red meat and fish hang from the hooks. Entering the smokehouse while it is in use is difficult as there is little air to breathe. A successful DC 10 Constitution saving throw is needed after the first minute to avoid gaining 1 level of exhaustion. The adventurer must attempt an additional saving throw every minute thereafter with the same result. Creatures that do not breathe or hold their breath do not need to make these saving throws.

In a separated area inside the smokehouse is a storeroom filled with salt, charcoal, and lumber. A hidden cache is located under a paving stone covered by the lumber and is found with a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check. Inside, wrapped in oiled cloth, are a number of old weapons taken from the pirates who invaded the island sixty years ago. Inside there are also the captains' logs of the *Audacity* and the merchant vessel *Abundant Serendipity* that was its prey. Together, these logs tell the story of the merchant ship loaded with gold, gems, and works of art and books of lore out of Melvaunt and headed for Mulmaster when it was taken by Captain Reeve Sar Testain and the *Audacity*. It further describes how the pirate crew took refuge on the island and enslaved the villagers. The pirate captain's log ends with over two dozen blank pages left in it.

NPCs. Ulburto is a large, bearded man whose arms are not the same length. His right arm is much longer and stronger than his left, which is half the size of the other. He was a child when the pact was made and while he did not participate in the ceremony, he knows the truth of the village. He is a strong and stern man, who speaks little. His quiet strength has made him the default leader of the villager, but it is only a veneer stretched thin over a boundless rage.

- Ulburto stares much and speaks and little, using as few words as possible. He is frequently butchering meat or gutting fish in front of the smokehouse except at midday, when he goes to the fire pit to sit and listen to the stories of the crones.
- He is concerned about all the outsiders coming to his village and he knows that they will only bring trouble, and trouble needs to be killed... and then possibly butchered and smoked for leaner times. Ulburto is not above a little cannibalism between friends.
- If approached about the coming raid, there is the faintest twitch of a smile at the corner of his mouth and he can be easily won over to any plans to

defend the village that involve violence.

- If he catches anyone in his smokehouse, he orders them out. Those who refuse, or are caught in the storage area digging up the floor are immediately attacked.
- A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check reveals that Ulburto is a violently dangerous man.
- To convince Ulburto to aid the adventurers, see "Rallying the Villagers" below.

THE DARK WOOD

For a small island with generations of inhabitants, the woods are oddly thick and dark. Filled with pines, walnuts, hawthorns, and dense underbrush of thorny plants, it is not a pleasant place to walk. A few squirrels and rodents manage to survive in it.

Elisande: "No, mustin walk the dark wood. The creatures gobble you!"

Searching. Searching the Dark Wood will take significant time compared to other locations and should be considered two of the adventurers' three actions for the day. Those that search the woods automatically find the cave with the infernal altar described below. Should an adventurer or group of adventurers want to do a quick exploration of the woods, they must succeed in a DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) check to find it.

NPCs. The creature in the woods is a horrible puddle of flowing flesh with vaguely humanoid features called a lemure. It is bound to serve Warsh and the crones and responds to their mental call anywhere on the island. It avoids the adventurers at all cost hiding in the woods unless they find the infernal altar (see below), or the village is attacked and it is needed in the defense.

The fetish from the ruined hovel grows hot when the lemure approaches.

INFERNAL ALTAR

On the other side of the island, a fifteen minute walk through the thickest part of the dark wood, filled with briars and nettles, there is a cave at the bottom of a water filled ravine. Climbing down to the cave is dangerous. Those that fail a DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check fall, taking 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage on the rocks below.

The fetish from the ruined hovel grows hot when approaching the ravine.

Elisande: "Was is da? Mussin' be ya creature of the woods lair!" (*Her eyes go wide, filled with fear.*)

Searching: The five-foot-wide rough cave moves up and towards the center of the island for sixty feet, so that

the floor is dry, before opening into a roughly thirty by forty foot wide room with an altar in the center.

In the center of a large room is a roughly rectangular block of stone, blotches of rust colored stains dripped from its center. Several darkened candles are melted to the stone and a collection of ritual objects are on the center of the block. The walls are painted in crude artwork depicting a five-headed sea serpent rising from the waves, feasting upon stick figures on the shore. Another stick figure standing on the water is pouring a sack of what could be coins into the waves. Something about the place raises the hairs on the back of your neck. There is a wrongness here.

The room is under the effects of a **lingering magic** (school of illusion) that causes unease in anyone approaching. Anyone who does not worship infernals or Tiamat and attempts to enter the room must succeed in a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw or gain the *frightened* condition and be unable to do so. Overcome with a growing horror that they cannot name, the victim has the urge to flee the cave as soon as possible.

Examining the room, there are several things of interest.

- A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Religion) check made while examining the artwork on walls implies that the creature may actually be a variant of Tiamat, the deity of evil dragons and greed. It is rare for humanoids to worship her, but sometimes involves a sacrifice of wealth.
- A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check notes that no one has been in this room for many years.
- Amid several gold bars on the altar is a silver plated ritual knife. It will serve as a dagger, but is poorly made and the silver begins to flake off when used in combat. It does not survive past this adventure.
- The gold bars all bear a trade stamp dating back 60 years, but look to be in good condition, as if they have seen little to no use.
- Also on the altar is a scroll sealed with a splotch of red wax. If opened, all the candles of the room flare to life. The scroll appears to be a contract between "Servants of the Queene" and the "Folk." It details the deal struck sixty years ago in which the islanders traded their souls and a fortune in gold and gems in exchange for personal power and casting away the "Outsides"—unless the deal is broken. How the deal is broken is not specified, but it matters not, the adventurers have already broken it.

- A pile of books lie in the corner. Most are rotted with moisture and useless, but a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) finds a tome that is particularly old and appears to be written on some sort of leather. The Draconic writing is faded badly, but with a few hours, it can be deciphered. It details the final resting place of one of the Dragon Masks, although, unbeknownst to the adventurers, the mask has since been located and claimed by the Cult of the Dragon.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the adventurers enter the cave, the lemure from the dark wood begins moving towards the cave. It attacks as soon as adventurers climb out of the ravine.

TREASURE

There is 200 gp in old gold trade bars piled on the altar. They appear to have seen little use, despite bearing a trade stamp that is sixty years old.

RALLYING THE VILLAGERS

It is likely that the adventurers will attempt to rally the villagers to the defense of the village, telling them that a strike by a ghost ship of undead may be imminent. The villagers are strangely apathetic about such claims. They do not trust the "Outsides" and their stories and instead wait for their leaders to decide how the Folk should proceed.

The party will need to sway at least two of the three votes to their cause in order to get the villagers to work with them: Warsh, Ulburto and the crones. If the adventurers succeed, the villagers aid in fortifying the town and fighting with the adventurers (see "Fortifying the Village," below). If they fail they will not aid the adventurers until it is clear that the raid is in progress, at which point they will have no choice.

CONVINCING WARSH

Warsh likes hard work and plain talk, but he is also greedy. In order to convince him to side with the adventurers, they must succeed in a DC 20 Charisma (Persuasion) check with the following cumulative modifiers.

- +2 for a gift of coins or items totaling at least 20 gp, with a further +1 for every 10 gp over, rounded down.
- +2 for an adventurer that has completed some sort of defense already, such as building a palisade, a trap or digging a ditch.

- The check is made with **disadvantage** if a character claims to be a pirate.

CONVINCING THE CRONES

The crones enjoy being entertained, particularly games of riddles and lies. In order to gain their trust they must succeed in a DC 25 Charisma (Deception or Persuasion) check with the following cumulative modifiers.

- +2 if the adventurer entertains them with a successful DC 15 Performance check.
- +5 if the adventurer can beat them in a game of riddles. This requires successful DC 15 Charisma (Deception) check and a DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) checks. If the adventurer makes one, but not both, they play another round until they fail or make both.
- +2 for a gift of coins or items totalling 75 gp or more.
- The check is made with **advantage** if a character flatters the crones with talk of their beauty.

CONVINCING ULBURTO

Ulburto does not especially like talking, but he loves fighting. To convince him to help the adventurers rally the villagers they must succeed in a DC 20 Charisma (Deception or Persuasion) check with the following cumulative modifiers.

- +5 if they promise a violent confrontation.
- +2 if the adventurer tries to use Strength (Athletics) or Charisma (Intimidate) to impress him.
- +2 if the adventurer has the Rage ability.
- +2 if the adventurers offer him food or drink.
- The check is made with **disadvantage** if a character tries to flatter him with kind words or sweet talk.

FORTIFYING THE VILLAGE

Martially oriented adventurers may realize that they have an opportunity to prepare for a raid that seems likely to happen this very night. It is clear that the village is not very defensible as it is now, not ever built to withstand an attack.

Here are some examples of things the adventurers might do to repel the attackers along with some possible game mechanics. It is impossible to imagine every clever idea, so the DM should feel free to improvise. In general 3 (1d6) points of damage (or 2 (1d4) points in a 10'x10' square) and saving throw DCs of 10-15 are generally appropriate. Each trap or obstacle takes one day action unless it says otherwise.

- **Palisade:** Wood is very valuable on the island, especially since many of the surviving trees produce nuts or fruit, so the villagers are very hesitant to build a wall, but the adventurers should be able to convince the villagers to use rubble from the abandoned or destroyed hovels to build a low wall in order to funnel most attackers. Building a stable wall requires a successful DC 15 Strength or Intelligence check to complete in one action (of the three each adventurer or group of adventurers have). Otherwise it takes two.
- **Ditch:** Requires a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect. Digging ditches around the village is easy in the mud, and the rapidly fill with dirty water from the rain, making it easy to hide hooks, thorn bushes, or other dangerous debris inside them. The ditch is difficult terrain and if filled with obstacles does 2 (1d4) points of piercing damage. Succeeding at a DC 10 Dexterity halves this damage. No roll is needed to dig the ditch, only time. Ditches filled with oil can be set ablaze for 2 (1d4) points of fire damage each round.
- **Pits:** Requires a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect. Hidden pits are difficult to make as they fill with water quickly, making it necessary to line them with spikes or other debris in order to do 3 (1d6) points of piercing damage. A successful DC 15 Dexterity saving throw avoids the pit. Pits filled with oil can be set ablaze for 2 (1d4) points of fire damage each round. Succeeding at a DC 10 Strength or Intelligence check is required to build a series of pits without having them collapse on themselves.
- **Hooked Nets:** Requires a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect. Dodging a dropped net requires a successful DC 10 Dexterity saving throw. Failure restrains each Large or smaller creature within 5 feet of that point. A creature can break free by dealing 5 slashing damage to the net or by succeeding on a DC 10 Strength check using its action. If there are hooks sewn into the net, it does 1 point of damage each round the creature struggles or tries to free itself.
- **Trip Lines:** Requires a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect. Trip lines can be set to trip foes making them prone. Any adventurer that doesn't see a trip line must succeed at a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or fall prone.
- **Swinging Weight Traps:** Requires a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to detect. Heavy

objects that wing from a height at head or mid-level do 3 (1d6) points of bludgeoning damage and can be avoided by succeeding at DC 15 Dexterity saving throw. Determine how high the weights are placed, small creatures (such as kobolds) will often be missed.

FIGHTING THE VILLAGERS

It is quite possible that during their searches, the adventurers uncover mounting evidence that the villagers are not innocent victims that need protection. Should the secret of the pact be exposed, or the adventurers simply make too much of a nuisance, it is possible they end up fighting the villagers before the raid ever occurs. This is not the intention of the adventure, but is certainly possible.

If a conflict occurs out of sight of the rest of the village and the adventurers hide evidence of violence, they can avoid an all-out riot and they may proceed as normal. If not, several of the villagers rush to aid their fellows against the “Outsides.” This can quickly become a challenging fight if the adventurers are not prepared or working together.

If there is a combat, two **commoners**, **Warsh**, **Ulburto** (use **scout** statistics), and the **crones** (who summon the **lemure** to arrive in five rounds) try to kill all the adventurers. If Verik (use **commoner** statistics) still lives, they will go for him as well, making him an unexpected ally of the adventurers. Verik fights for his life. He intelligently coordinates attacks with the adventurers, but is not overly helpful. He’s out to save his own skin.

ADJUSTING THE ADVENTURE

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak party:** remove the crones (they flee to the Dark Wood), the lemure, and the commoners
- **Weak party:** remove the crones (they flee to the Dark Wood) and the lemure
- **Strong party:** add two commoners
- **Very strong party:** add two commoners and one scout

PART 4: BUMP IN THE NIGHT

This event begins as night falls on the seventeenth day since the attacks began, the day the adventurers arrived on the island. Ixas and his men are close at hand. If the adventurers have not already told you, determine where each one is at the start of the event.

Somewhere in the night sky above the thunderclouds, Selune has raised an old moon: a slim, fading crescent. In the wind and rain, its light is lost to you. However, through the sheets of water, a pale glow and swirl of fog unaffected by the storm approach the landing. Screams of the damned ride the wind.

Ixas' plan is twofold. A main group moves up the center of the island from the landing, relying on their disguises and magic to sow fear and disrupt the defenses. While at the same time, a smaller group has circled around and landed on the side of the island by stealth. They will attack from behind hoping to catch the village by surprise.

In both cases when they enemies make themselves known, describe the groups as twice as big as they are. This is not necessary if the adventurers have already come to blows with the villagers and eliminated the combat capable members of the Folk. These extra foes represent the foes that will be fought by the Folk. The main group is composed of six **kobolds** and one **bandit**. The group travelling by stealth has four **kobolds** and one **bandit**.

Two of the kobolds in the main group each possess two flasks of alchemist's fire. As an action, they may, this flask can be thrown up to 20 feet, shattering it on impact. Make a ranged attack against a target creature or object. On a hit, the target takes 2 (1d4) fire damage at the start of each of its turns. A creature can end this damage by using its action to attempt a DC 10 Dexterity check to extinguish the flames.

The raiders are looking to take captives and gather up potential valuables or tomes for their master. They take prisoners whenever possible. The kobolds are not used to a serious resistance and begin to hesitate once the adventurers have slain half of their number. In that case, they grab any captives or bounty and flee towards the landing.

As the fight continues, the Dungeon Master should describe the fel powers and bloodthirsty tactics used by

the villagers, including the infernal words followed by blasts of hellfire and the domination of the lemure called forth by one of the crones as she cuts her arm for a blood sacrifice. By the end of the fight, the adventurers should feel very uncomfortable about their "allies."

ADJUSTING THE ADVENTURE

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak party:** remove six kobolds (four from the main group, two from the rear group)
- **Weak party:** remove four kobolds (two from each group)
- **Strong party:** add five kobolds (three to the main group, two to the rear group)
- **Very strong party:** add five kobolds (three to the main group, two to the rear group), change the bandits to scouts

GENERAL FEATURES

The exact features of the combat area vary with where the adventurers have positioned themselves. There are ample places to find cover or concealment and the battlefield will be altered by the preparations of the adventurers. The Dungeon Master should feel free to adjust accordingly.

Light. The moon is behind the clouds and the rain is pouring heavily. The entire area is dimly lit if the adventurers allowed the villagers to keep the fire pit burning and place torches or lanterns about. If not, it is darkness.

Disguise. The kobolds and sailors are all wearing disguises of old bones, skulls and dirt so as to appear as shambling undead risen from the sea floor. The kobold alchemist has gone so far as to paint himself and his cloak with a phosphorescent paint so that he glows and appears as a spectral wizard throwing small balls of fire. A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Religion) check is needed to determine they are not undead at range, but the DC drops to 10 if the adventurer is adjacent to one of them. There may be reasons for irrefutable proof that require no check at the DM's discretion.

Storm. The storm is raging. Any Wisdom (Perception) checks made to see or hear suffer disadvantage and sounds carries clearly only a few feet. Ranged attacks beyond normal range suffer disadvantage and cannot be made at the maximum range.

VERIK

If Verik is still alive and not restrained, he does his best to help his allies based on the preparations he has been